

Capacity Assessment on Anti-bullying Mechanisms: Strengthening Project CALL (Creating Adaptive Lifelong Learners) in a Public Secondary School in the Philippines

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Abstract

The relationship between teachers' capacity to employ anti-bullying approaches and the extent of bullying prevalence was investigated. Teachers underwent assessment regarding their knowledge and capacity on different approaches to address bullying cases and how this ability affects the likelihood of bullying manifestations observed among secondary students. While it is essential for teachers to be proactive in preventing bullying since bullying brings risks for a host of negative outcomes, schools are encouraged to strengthen program and policy implementations. This study used a descriptive-correlation design to assess 24 teachers and a sample of 25 students. An adopted survey questionnaires were used to collect data and parametric tests were used to analyze the data. Findings revealed that teachers have "Slight" knowledge about Anti-bullying Programs and Policies, with no relevant training and lesser strategies employed. Anti-bullying capacity is found to be "Slight" in both Proactive and Reactive Approaches. "Indirect" bullying emerged more prevalent than "direct" and "cyber-bullying". Correlation reflected a significant relationship between teachers' capacity for bullying. It shows that teachers play a vital role in lessening bullying occurrences in schools. The findings recommend strengthening anti-bullying mechanisms and capacitating teachers with anti-bullying approaches to promote academic improvement among students.

Keywords: Anti-bullying Mechanisms, Capacity Assessment, Bullying Manifestations, Project CALL, DepEd

Introduction

Capacity building in addressing bullying in schools has received research attention for its role in providing a safe and conducive place to learn as an aspect of quality academic learning (Aluede, 2011). Based on DepEd Order No.40, s. 2012, it is the duty of every school to promote equality and diversity as well as ensure the safety and well-being of students. Participatory and other rights of children must be respected and upheld in all matters and procedures affecting their welfare. As a matter of fact, the prevention and response to school bullying has become an important issue, not only in America, Europe and Oceania (Lin, 2014 & Smith et al., 2016) but also more recently in Asian countries (Chung, 2017).

School bullying remains an issue nowadays especially for the present generation of learners. Surveys can prove that being repeatedly bullied in school increase the possibility of health risk. The World Health Organization (WHO) in the year 2016 have reported that bullying is prevalent among 42 countries around the world that up to 11% of students have reported being involved in school bullying or victimization. In relation to this, the study of Norshidah (2014) revealed that bullying occurs more in secondary schools and this is caused by teenagers with high level of

egocentrism. Self-esteem, vengeance, enjoyment, authority and part of prejudice were the factors that influences bullying in school.

The Center for Disease Control and Prevention (2016) coined that school bullying is a malicious process in which youths are subjected to unwanted aggressive behaviors from either another youth or group of youths who are neither intimate partners nor siblings. To add, Rigby (2002) posited that bullying is an aggressive or insulting behavior by an individual or group, often repeated over a period of time that intentionally hurts or harms. Researches (Forero, 1999, Sourander, 2005, Wolke et al., 2013) proved the destructive effects of bullying on ones lives. It can affect attitude and performance in school (Juvonen & Graham, 2014). Knowledge of the interventions and their usefulness can provide help identify and promote effective mechanisms of addressing student-to-student bullying. These interventions have something to do with what teachers knew about evidence-based findings related to bullying. Assessing teachers' knowledge and capacity on bullying is relevant to ensure teachers are workable to address problems. It is important to provide actions to take to deal more effectively with student-to-student bullying cases that seem to grow presently.

Every teacher is considered front liner in preventing and tackling bullying issues and protecting the well-being of the most vulnerable communities in which

diversity is valued and the weak protected. However, actions related to helping teachers in dealing with school bullying—intervening in school bullying when it occurs still attract relatively less attention in the school level (Huang, 2018). Moreover, bullying can occur in different manners in which most teachers are not aware of it transpiring among students, hence, is difficult to apprehend dynamic precautions (Psunder, 2010). What teachers need in Ibarra NHS is training regarding to the strategies or approaches to effectively and efficiently deal about bullying issues and assisting them in making an appropriate and effective choice of methods. It is believed that training can increase teacher's understanding of the harmful effects of bullying Xie *et al.* (2002) and can lead to full internalization of their role as peace keepers in the school, or in the classroom in particular. This endeavor can also be a reinforcement of the school's project banner Creating Adaptive Lifelong Learners (CALL) by igniting the anti-bullying program and by equipping teachers enough skills to solve bullying cases met in every day's experience with students.

Research Questions

This study in general attempts to determine the relationship between the anti-bullying capacity of teachers and the extent of bullying manifestations among high school students in Ibarra National High School to gain evidence-based inputs for strong inclusion in Project CALL. Specifically, this study sought answers to the following questions:

1. What is the profile of teachers in terms of
 - a. training received about anti-bullying
 - b. number of encountered situations on bullying
 - c. extent of understanding of anti-bullying programs and policy
 - d. current interventions employed to address bullying
2. What is the level of capacity of teachers in terms of,
 - a. Proactive anti-bullying approaches;
 - b. Reactive anti-bullying approaches?
3. How often the students experience the following forms of bullying:
 - a. Face-to-face or Direct
 - b. Covert or Indirect
 - c. Online or Cyberbullying
4. Is there a significant relationship between teacher level of anti-bullying capacity and learners bullying manifestations?

Literature Review

Filipino researchers, Cardona, Reyes, and Tangalin (2015) defined bullying as a repeated verbal, physical, social or psychological aggressive behavior by a person or group directed towards a less powerful person or group that is intended to cause harm, distress or fear. Also called peer violence by the Council for the Welfare of Children and UNICEF Philippines (2016), bullying is unwanted, aggressive behavior among school-aged children that involves a real or perceived power imbalance which makes use of force, threats, or coercion to abuse, intimidate, or aggressively dominate others. The behavior is often repeated and habitual. Bullying is therefore a kind of social aggression that is most observable in schools, than in other social avenues. However, what sets bullying apart from other aggressive attacks is its 'repeated' nature, which is reinforced by the silence and powerlessness of the victim (Bibou-Nakou, Tsiantis, Assimopoulos, Chatzilambou, & Giannakopoulou, 2012).

According to literatures, bullying can be understood to occur in three forms: face-to-face bullying, covert bullying and online bullying. Face-to-face bullying, also called direct bullying, is overt and easier for adults to detect. It can include physical actions such as punching or kicking, and verbal actions such as name-calling and insulting (Ministerial Council for Education, Early Childhood Development and Youth Affairs 2011). Covert bullying, also called indirect bullying, is hidden from adults. It can include behaviors such as spreading rumors, excluding, threatening, blackmailing, whispering and stealing friends (Cross et al. 2009). Although covert bullying was previously perceived as less harmful than direct bullying, it is now recognized as having significant potential for serious harm (Cross et al. 2009; Smith et al. 2008a; Sourander et al. 2010). One study revealed that male students are more inclined towards direct bullying, whereas female student are towards indirect bullying (Boyes et al., 2014). The last form of bullying which is found to be alarming in these times is online bullying. Also called cyber bullying, is a specific type of covert bullying that uses electronic forms of contact (Smith et al. 2008a; Sourander et. al. 2010).

According to Nor et al. (2019), bully victims normally experience agitation, embarrassment and exasperation which consequently caused them to be timid, self-isolated from their friends, play truant, changed personality, sensitive, melancholy and suicidal. Furthermore, its effects on the victim include declining

performance due to loss of interest in learning, skipping classes and skipping school out of fear, self-blame together with the uncertainty about one's abilities and potential. Thus, Jennings et al. (2017) have identified these effects to hold severe and lasting effects on the victim.

The work of schools in countering bullying is commonly classified under two headings: proactive and reactive (Rigby & Johnson, 2016). These two approaches are not entirely distinct. The former refers to steps that are taken to prevent bullying from occurring; the latter to steps taken when bullying has occurred and action is needed to resolve the problem. Hence, the school especially the teachers play a crucial role in facilitating appropriate interventions in school-related bullying cases. According to teachers, bullying often occurs in the classroom (Nouran, 2015). Teachers are more likely to address bullying if they believe the problem is serious, feel empathy for bullied students, perceive that they have key roles to play in reducing bullying and believe that their intervention will be effective (Kallistad & Olweus, 2003). Along with this, establishing an appropriate atmosphere is important for the implementation of intervention in school bullying. Building positive relationship with the students involve and showing appropriate attitudes and therefore enhance student's willingness to cooperate with teachers when implementing an intervention (Storer et al., 2017) and building capacity in teachers entails supporting teacher motivation and skills in both program specific and general ways (Wandersman et al., 2008).

Schools continuously try to overcome bullying by employing a variety of strategies with the school policies. These strategies are crucial to consider because the impact of bullying is very complex. Programs to stop bullying are moral movements that must be fought by schools. To adequately develop and sustain positive behavior change to a systematic problem, it is recommended that the whole school community model, support and reinforce student's newly developed positive behavior, attitude and understanding about bullying and modify the environment to support these changes (Cross et al., 2012). As such, the study of Jimenez-Barbero et al. (2016) found out that anti-bullying intervention and programs have significantly reduced the frequency of bullying cases and victimization among students.

The Department of Education (DepEd) documented more than 1,700 cases of bullying during the school year 2013-2014 and 60 % were only resolved according to Flores (2014). On a national account

performed by the Center for the Welfare of Children and UNICEF Philippines (2016), they included 3, 866 young respondents aged 13-24 to profile the violence done against Filipino children. Out of the different strands of child violence, peer violence or bullying had accounted for the 65% among the respondents who had experienced such act. Females reported higher lifetime prevalence during childhood (70%) than their male counterparts (59.8%) on the experience of bullying. Another local study on bullying was that of Gerardo (2016) which focused on determining the types and extent of bullying among the high school students in Cagayan. The paper found out that almost all respondents had experienced the three types of bullying (physical, social and verbal) which lasted for an average of less than a week. It also concluded that such forms of bullying were able to negatively affect the respondents' well-being: physical, emotional, intellectual, social, behavioral and creative.

Capacitating internal and external stakeholders would mean establishing policy interventions. One advantage of policy interventions for bullying is that they can influence student, teacher, and administrator behavior as well as school organizational practices. For example, school bullying policies typically prohibit certain behaviors, such as threatening and harassing other students or retaliating against students who witness and then report bullying incidents. Policies may also require behaviors, such as requiring teachers to report bullying incidents to administrators and requiring administrators to investigate reports of bullying. Further, policies may promote certain behaviors by explicitly stating positive behavioral expectations for students or discourage behaviors by explicitly stating punishments associated with aggressive behaviors. At the school level, policies can guide organizational practices, such as establishing bullying incident reporting procedures and creating school-safety teams tasked with developing and executing school-safety plans. Thus, bullying policies can influence individual and organizational behaviors (Hall, 2017).

Policy design is important because the content influences a cascade of actions throughout school systems, which may result in positive or negative outcomes. For example, a bullying policy that requires schools to provide counseling services and positive behavioral reinforcement to students who perpetrate bullying is markedly different than a policy that requires schools to suspend or expel students who have carried out multiple acts of bullying. Research shows that overly harsh and punitive policies (e.g., "three strikes and you're out" policies or "zero-tolerance"

policies) are not effective at reducing aggression or improving school safety (American Psychological Association Zero Tolerance Task Force, 2008). Thus, bullying policies should be crafted and revised using evidence-based strategies.

Methodology

This study is quantitative research utilizing a descriptive-correlational design. A correlational approach endeavors to find relationships between two covariates, or independent behaviors, situations, or events.

Participants

All teachers of the school were purposively selected. For the students, 5 representatives from each level (Grade 8-12) were randomly selected to answer the questions. The group and teachers and students were separately scheduled to answer the survey questionnaire. Ethical standards were observed during the collection and interpretation of data.

Instruments of the Study

To collect data, an adopted indicator for the questionnaire from the Australian Centre for Education Statistics and Evaluation ACESE (2017) was utilized to measure the level of anti-bullying capacity of teachers in terms of proactive and reactive approaches ranging at a scale of 4. To determine the extent of bullying manifestations among students, and adopted questionnaire from Rigby and Johnson (2016) was used. These instruments were administered to some 24 purposively sampled classroom teachers and 25 randomly sampled students.

Procedure

Parametric tests used were frequency, mean, standard deviation, Chi-square analysis, and Pearson-r with significantly less than 5% level. The data were treated using Minitab 17.

Ethical Considerations

The researchers sent an approval letter to the school principal for information and to ask for permission to conduct the study. After the approval of the school principal, the researchers first distributed the survey questionnaire to the teachers and were instructed to be filled out during their vacant time. The researchers also sent a letter to the teachers to ask for permission

the conduct the study with the randomly selected students. Moreover, the researchers explained that all information gathered during the survey will be utilized for this research only. The anonymity of the respondents was also observed.

Result and Discussion

Profile of Teacher with regards to Anti-bullying

Reflected in Table 1 below is the profile of teachers related to anti-bullying. Results revealed that almost all teachers have not received any training related to anti-bullying (N=23). Most of them observed bullying in the “7 & up” range. However, the respondents’ level of understanding of related policies is “Slight”. Mostly have lesser interventions (N=12) known for solving conflicts on bullying. This implies that most of the teachers are not totally equipped with anti-bullying backgrounds which is why control of bullying could be weak in terms of effective mechanisms.

Table 1. *Profile of Teachers on Anti-Bullying*

Number of teachers with...	Frequency			
	None	1-3	4-6	7 & up
...bullying incidents met by teachers in a SY	0	2	4	18
...training Received related to Anti-bullying	23	1	0	0
...interventions prepared for solving bullying conflicts	9	12	3	0
	High	Moderate	Slight	Low
Level of understanding on anti-bullying policies	0	4	15	5
Total (N=24)				

Anti-bullying Capacity of Teachers in Terms of Different Approaches

The capacity level of teachers in using interventions is shown in the table below. Mean results indicate that teachers are slightly capacitated both in proactive approaches (M=2.07) and Reactive approaches (M=2.45). On average, teachers are slightly capacitated (M=2.26) to deliver such approaches. This implies that teachers do not have sufficient background when it comes to the execution of different approaches that could be helpful to consistently minimize bullying in school. This is supported by the studies of Farrington and Ttofi (2009), Bauman and Del Rio (2005), and Rigby (2002).

Table 2. *Anti-bullying Capacity of Teachers in terms of different approaches*

Anti-bullying Approaches/Strategies and Practices	Level	Description
PROACTIVE APPROACHES	2.07	Slight
• Effective monitoring and supervision of pupils	3.80	High
• Explicit teaching in promoting positive behavior among learners with inclusion of anti-bullying content in the classroom that allows students to develop social and emotional competencies and learn appropriate ways to respond to bullying.	2.33	Slight
• Developing a school-wide anti-bullying policy	1.22	Low
• Developing an effective anti-bullying mechanism such as a holistic whole school approach	1.36	Low
• Establishing preventative strategies that target key environments in which bullying is known to occur including the classroom and the playground	1.40	Low
• Promoting a culture of "reporting the bullying".	2.39	Slight
• Partnering with parents and carers	1.18	Low
• Building Buddy Programs to promote peer support	2.41	Slight
• promoting good classroom management that prevents anti-bullying in the classroom	3.46	Moderate
• Building a Social and Emotional Learning (SEL) programs as a structured way to improve a wide range of students' social and emotional skills.	2.50	Moderate
• Promoting upstander behavior	2.27	Slight
• Providing effective support and professional development for school staff	1.38	Low
• Systematic implementation and evaluation of Anti-bullying practices	1.30	Low
REACTIVE APPROACHES	2.453	Slight
• Imposing direct sanctions in responding to cases of bullying	3.41	Moderate
• Building a restorative practice (actions based on the concept of restorative justice, and prioritizes repairing harm done to relationships over the need to assign blame and dispense punishment (Wong et al. 2011)).	1.23	Slight
• Using a mediation approach	3.5	High
• Using 'Support Group Method to resolve bullying behavior without the high degree of coercion evident in either direct sanctions or restorative practice	2.03	Slight
• Using Method of Shared Concern / Pikas Method, a non-punitive approach for working with groups of students involved in bullying, and seeks to empower students to negotiate a solution to the issue through a series of meetings with a trained practitioner	1.46	Low
• Consistent recording, investigation and follow up of bullying behavior (including use of established intervention strategies);	3.00	Moderate
• Conducting research to address issues identified as significant to anti-bullying	1.40	Low
• Seeking out and act on student feedback on the helpfulness of actions taken by the school in addressing bullying	3.60	High
Over-all Mean	2.26	Slight

Legend: 3.51-4.00 (High); 2.51-3.50 (Moderate); 1.51-2.50 (Slight); 1.00-1.50 (Low)

Bullying Manifestations among High School Students

There are several types of bullying that usually prevail on school campuses. Table 3 shows the extent to which students encounter bullying in their day-to-day experiences in school. It can be noted from the results that the most prevalent issue is Indirect Bullying ($M=2.53$). This implies that finding means to address this is the full responsibility of the school. Hence, the anti-bullying approaches of teachers are a practical mechanism in this aspect considering the risks it will give directions to the student victims. Systematic anti-bullying procedures can help prevent further problems that may affect academic performance and enrollment status. Hence, capacitating teachers can be a good step to help reinforce and strengthen the anti-bullying implementation at the school level (Ttofi & Farrington, 2011).

Table 3. *Bullying manifestations of High School students*

Bullying Manifestations of Students	Extent	Description
Face to Face Bullying (Direct)	2.26	Sometimes
• hit, kicked, push around	2.40	Sometimes
• Made fun of or teased in a mean and hurtful way	3.72	Often
• Ignored, left out or not allowed to join in	3.66	Often
• taking or damaging belongings	1.42	Never
• experienced being taunted, mocked and insulted/name calling	2.20	Sometimes
• Sexual harassment by another student	1.00	Never
• Harassing students because of their race	1.44	Never
Covert Bullying (Indirect)	2.53	Quite Often
• Lies or nasty stories to make other kids not like me	3.00	Quite Often
• Made afraid of getting hurt	3.42	Quite Often
• excluding someone from social groups	3.03	Quite Often
• blackmailed	1.34	Never
• threatened	2.50	Sometimes
• made by others the subject of malicious rumors	1.89	Sometimes
Online bullying or Cyber bullying	2.17	Sometimes
• Sent harassing texts or emails	2.30	Sometimes
• Cruel things said online or in social network, e.g., Facebook	3.41	Quite Often
• received offensive or degrading images by phone or the internet, producing offensive	1.60	Sometimes
• graffiti.	1.35	Never
Over-all Mean	2.32	Sometimes

Legend: 3.51-4.00 (Often); 2.51-3.50 (Quite Often); 1.51-2.50 (Sometimes); 1.00-1.50 (Never)

Test Results on the Significance of Relationship between Anti-bullying Capacity of Teachers and Bullying Manifestations of Students

Using chi-square analysis, results shown in the next

table is the significance level between the variables tested. Apparently, test reflects significant of relationship ($\alpha=0.0204<0.05$) between teachers' capacity level and the prevalence of bullying manifestations. This implies that anti-bullying capacity is an essential aspect to reduce cases of bullying manifestations among students. Looking into the development of anti-bullying initiatives can help strengthen the school to boost its place for better learning which in return contributes so much to the academic needs of learners and enable them to remain focused and improve their performance. The finding is supported by the results of the study by Ttofi and Farrington (2011), Jiménez-Barbero et al. (2016), Lee et. al., (2015), and Evans et. al. (2014).

Table 4. *Relationship between Teachers' Anti-bullying Capacity and Students' Bullying manifestations*

Variables Tested		Coefficient	P-value
Independent	Dependent		
Teacher's Capacity Level	Bullying Manifestations	.98*	0.0204

*Relationship is significant at $p<0.05$

Conclusion

From the results gathered, the following points are concluded:

- Most of the teachers are not totally equipped with anti-bullying backgrounds which is why control of bullying could be weak in terms of effective mechanisms.
- Teachers do not have sufficient background when it comes to the execution of different approaches that could be helpful to consistently minimize bullying in school
- The common type of bullying that is observed inside the school is Indirect Bullying
- Anti-bullying capacity is an essential aspect to reduce cases of bullying manifestations among students

It can be concluded that the result of the assessment to Ibarra national High School showed a strong connection between their anti-bullying capacity and the prevalence of bullying manifestations among learners as reflected in the significance of correlation. Therefore, equipping teachers with timely and effective approaches is a valuable mechanism for attaining the goal of a bullying-free learning environment at Ibarra National High School. It is recommended that reinforcement of anti-bullying

programs in school could be integrated as an essential part of Project CALL to strengthen its value to learning development.

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